



traditions, including power over spirits and demons. He is also said to have fallen from divine grace after failing to put his worship of God before earthly matters. This rich set of characteristics made him attractive to followers of many kinds of ritual magic, and resulted in the development of a form of magic with Solomonic features.

Seals and symbols

Solomonic magic rituals often included symbols linked to a magic ring, the Seal of Solomon, said to have been a gift

from God that gave King Solomon power over demons. Symbols involving shapes and stars with five, six, or seven sides or points were commonly associated with Solomon's ring, and were often surrounded by a circle. These were represented on artifacts known as pentacles that were said to act as protective talismans, or to have the ability to invoke or repel spirits.

Many books believed to have been written by Solomon or to be based on his wisdom were in circulation during the Renaissance, including the Lesser Key of Solomon, an anonymous spell book from the mid-1600s that gave directions on how to contact both angelic and demonic spirits. The popularity of such texts is testament to the allure of this strand of ceremonial magic.

▲ Summoned from hell

In this 15th-century image, five demons, led by Belial, appear before Solomon and Moses. Solomon was said to influence demons using holy power, but some magicians sought to use this influence for corrupt purposes.

► Cosmic squares

Magic-square talismans used astrological magic to try to draw on planetary forces. In this 1651 Jupiter square, the numbers total 34 when added in any direction.

Y			
16	3	2	13
5	10	11	8
9	6	7	12
4	15	14	1